

Hackathon/ Innovation Problem Statements

1. Partnership Discovery Platform

Build a platform that connects NGOs, startups, government departments, universities, funders, and volunteers based on common SDG goals, geography, skills, and project needs.

2. SDG Funding Transparency System

Create a solution to track donations, grants, CSR funds, and project spending from funder to beneficiary, with public dashboards and impact reporting.

3. Rural-Corporate Collaboration Portal

Develop a digital platform where rural communities can post real problems—water, education, health, farming, jobs—and companies or institutions can sponsor and solve them.

4. SDG Project Impact Dashboard

Build a dashboard that measures whether partnership projects are producing real outcomes, such as students trained, jobs created, water saved, emissions reduced, or women supported.

5. Technology Access for NGOs

Create a low-cost platform that helps small NGOs access cloud tools, AI, digital marketing, CRM, accounting, training, and volunteer management.

6. Global Volunteer Skill-Matching App

Develop an app that matches professionals, students, mentors, and volunteers with nonprofit projects based on their skills, language, availability, and location.

7. Multilingual SDG Collaboration Tool

Build a collaboration platform that supports Tamil, Hindi, English, and other languages so local communities can participate in international development projects.

8. CSR-to-SDG Mapping Platform

Create a tool for companies to map their CSR activities to SDG targets, identify gaps, find implementation partners, and publish verified impact reports.

9. Shared Data Platform for Social Problems

Build a secure data-sharing system where government bodies, NGOs, researchers, and companies can share non-sensitive data to solve local issues faster.

10. Local Innovation Marketplace

Create a marketplace where local innovators can submit sustainable solutions and connect with investors, governments, incubators, and pilot-project partners.

11. School–Industry–Government Partnership System

Develop a platform that connects schools and colleges with companies and government programs for internships, skill training, innovation challenges, and employment

12. Cross-Border Disaster Response Coordination

Build a real-time coordination system for disaster relief that connects authorities, hospitals, NGOs, donors, logistics providers, and volunteers.

13. Partnership Trust Score

Develop a verification and rating system for NGOs, social enterprises, funders, and projects based on compliance, past impact, financial transparency, and beneficiary feedback.

14. AI-Based SDG Partner Recommendation Engine

Build an AI tool that recommends the best organizations, funders, technologies, or experts for a specific sustainability project.

15. Small Business Sustainability Network

Create a platform that helps MSMEs collaborate with sustainability experts, banks, government schemes, suppliers, and buyers to adopt greener business practices.

How might we use technology, policy innovation, and community partnerships to solve a measurable global problem—such as clean water, food waste, climate resilience, education access, healthcare, or youth employment—at a scale that is affordable and inclusive?

The toughest high-impact areas for a 24-hour hackathon are climate resilience, water management, food waste, health access, education and jobs, disaster response, waste management, AI safety, and transparent public services.

Real time problems in India 2026

These are urgent, lived problems affecting people now, rather than only long-term policy topics.

16. Extreme heat and worker safety

Heatwaves are disrupting outdoor work, farming, construction, street vending, transport, schools, and household income. Workers often lack shade, drinking water, paid rest, cooling spaces, insurance, and heat-health alerts. Recent reporting shows severe heat is already affecting livelihoods and public health.

17. Water scarcity, groundwater depletion, and unequal supply

Cities, villages, farms, and industries compete for limited water. Key issues include unreliable municipal supply, tanker dependence, groundwater over-extraction, poor rainwater storage, sewage contamination, and drought risk. Urban growth and climate change are increasing pressure on water systems.

18. Air Pollution

Seasonal smog, vehicle emissions, construction dust, industrial pollution, and crop burning create serious health risks, especially in large cities. Delhi has recently introduced permanent winter anti-pollution measures because the problem returns each year at dangerous levels.

19. Youth unemployment and skills-to-jobs mismatch

Many graduates have degrees but lack practical experience, English communication, digital skills, portfolio projects, industry exposure, or access to employers. Exam disruptions and recruitment uncertainty can further affect students and job seekers.

20. Farmer income instability

Farmers face unpredictable rainfall, heat stress, water shortages, crop disease, rising input costs, market-price volatility, delayed payments, limited cold storage, and weak direct access to buyers. Heat and groundwater decline are already forcing crop changes in some areas.

21. Waste management and plastic pollution

Many towns still struggle with source segregation, collection reliability, informal waste-worker safety, landfill fires, e-waste, biomedical waste, and recycling-market access. The core issue is not only collecting waste, but tracking it from household to verified processing.

22. Urban traffic, road safety, and public transport gaps

Congestion reduces productivity and increases fuel use and pollution. Pedestrians, cyclists, schoolchildren, and two-wheeler riders face unsafe roads, while many growing cities need better last-mile public transport and parking management.

23. Affordable healthcare and access in rural areas

Families may face delayed diagnosis, high out-of-pocket costs, medicine availability issues, long travel to specialists, overcrowded hospitals, and weak follow-up care. Rural and remote areas continue to face gaps in health, water, education, and basic infrastructure.

24. Education quality and digital divide

Students need stronger foundational learning, teacher support, career guidance, affordable devices, internet access, practical skills, internships, and pathways from education to employment. Climate events such as heatwaves can also interrupt schooling.

25. Women's safety, workforce participation, and childcare

Safety during travel, unequal unpaid care work, limited childcare, lack of flexible jobs, and workplace barriers reduce economic participation. Heat-driven school closures can push more childcare responsibility onto women and affect their employment.

26. Cyber fraud, scams, and digital financial safety

UPI fraud, phishing, fake job offers, loan-app harassment, identity theft, deepfake scams, and social-media misinformation are increasing risks for citizens and small businesses. Many victims do not know how to report quickly or preserve evidence.

27. Public-service delivery and corruption leakages

People can face delays, unclear eligibility, middlemen, document errors, weak grievance tracking, and limited transparency in schemes, certificates, land records, permits, and local civic services.

28. Industrial pollution and environmental compliance

Communities near factories can face contaminated water, soil, or air, while regulators need better monitoring and faster complaint resolution. A recent case near Bengaluru involved official scrutiny after concerns about wastewater affecting agricultural wells near an electronics plant.

29. Housing affordability and informal settlements

Migrant workers and low-income families face high rents, overcrowding, insecure housing, inadequate sanitation, and long commutes. Fast urbanization is putting greater pressure on housing and municipal services.

30. Disaster preparedness

Floods, cyclones, landslides, heatwaves, and droughts require better early warnings, local evacuation planning, relief coordination, resilient infrastructure, and support for vulnerable communities. Research indicates more intense rainfall can increase landslide risk in northeast India.

Strong India-focused problem statements for a hackathon

- **How might we protect outdoor workers from extreme heat using affordable alerts, cooling access, hydration tracking, and employer compliance tools?**
- **How might we help households, apartments, farms, and local bodies measure, save, reuse, and share water during shortages?**
- **How might we connect students to verified internships, skill pathways, mentors, and local jobs based on their actual abilities rather than only certificates?**
- **How might we help farmers receive crop advice, weather alerts, market prices, storage access, and direct buyer connections in local languages?**
- **How might we prevent digital-payment and job scams through real-time fraud detection, Tamil-language awareness, and fast reporting support?**
- **How might we create a transparent waste-tracking system from household collection to recycling or safe disposal?**
- **How might we make government grievance reporting trackable, time-bound, multilingual, and resistant to middlemen?**
- **How might we provide low-cost preventive healthcare screening and follow-up for rural and low-income families?**

For Tamil Nadu, high-priority areas include water conservation, industrial pollution monitoring, heat protection, youth employment, MSME digitization, waste management, road safety, government-service access, and cyber-fraud prevention.

The world's toughest problems are interconnected: solving one often depends on progress in several others. The United Nations frames many of them through the 17 Sustainable Development Goals, but these are major global challenge areas suitable for research, startups, policy, or hackathons.

1. **Climate change and extreme weather** — Reducing greenhouse-gas emissions while helping communities adapt to floods, droughts, heat waves, sea-level rise, and crop loss.
2. **Clean energy transition** — Delivering affordable, reliable electricity while replacing fossil fuels with renewable energy, storage, smarter grids, and cleaner industry.
3. **Poverty and unequal opportunity** — Creating stable income, education, financial access, housing, and social protection for people excluded from economic growth.
4. **Food security and sustainable agriculture** — Feeding a growing population despite water shortages, soil degradation, climate shocks, food waste, and unequal food distribution.
5. **Water scarcity and sanitation** — Ensuring safe drinking water, wastewater treatment, irrigation efficiency, groundwater protection, and sanitation access.
6. **Healthcare access and pandemic preparedness** — Making quality healthcare affordable, improving maternal and child health, detecting outbreaks early, and strengthening public-health systems.
7. **Antimicrobial resistance** — Preventing bacteria and other pathogens from becoming resistant to antibiotics, which could make common infections and surgeries far more dangerous.
8. **Mental health and suicide prevention** — Expanding early support, affordable care, crisis response, workplace wellbeing, and access in underserved communities.
9. **Quality education and skills gaps** — Providing practical, affordable education and digital skills that prepare students for changing jobs and economies.
10. **Youth unemployment and future of work** — Helping young people gain employable skills while managing job displacement from automation and AI.
11. **Affordable housing and urban growth** — Building safe, low-cost housing, transport, waste systems, and public services for rapidly growing cities.
12. **Waste, plastic pollution, and circular economy** — Reducing single-use waste, improving recycling, repairing products, recovering materials, and preventing ocean pollution.
13. **Biodiversity loss and ecosystem collapse** — Protecting forests, oceans, wetlands, pollinators, wildlife habitats, and natural systems that support food, water, and climate stability.

14. **Conflict, displacement, and peacebuilding** — Preventing war, protecting civilians, supporting refugees, rebuilding communities, and reducing the conditions that lead to violence.
15. **Misinformation and digital trust** — Reducing scams, manipulated content, harmful misinformation, deepfakes, and online polarization without undermining legitimate speech.
16. **Cybersecurity and digital safety** — Protecting citizens, hospitals, banks, governments, businesses, and critical infrastructure from cybercrime and data theft.
17. **Ethical and safe artificial intelligence** — Ensuring AI is fair, transparent, secure, accountable, and beneficial while preventing misuse, discrimination, and concentration of power.
18. **Economic inequality and financial inclusion** — Making banking, credit, insurance, investment, and entrepreneurship accessible to low-income people and small businesses.
19. **Governance, corruption, and public-service delivery** — Improving transparency, reducing leakages, and making government services easier, faster, and more accountable.
20. **Global cooperation** — Aligning countries, companies, researchers, funders, and communities on shared action despite political, economic, and cultural differences.

For a global student hackathon, these can become strong challenge statements.